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As it is Written: The Brief Case for Karaism

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What is Karaism?

Karaism is the original form of Judaism commanded by God to the Jewish people in the Torah. Karaites accept the Tanach (Jewish Bible) as the word of God and as the sole religious authority. At the same time, Karaites deny human additions to the Torah such as the Rabbinic “Oral Law” (see *Logical and Textual Reasons why Karaites Reject the “Oral Law”*). For Deuteronomy 4:2 states, “Thou shall not add to the word which I have commanded you, neither shall you diminish from it. . .” Karaite Judaism also rejects the Rabbinical principle that the Rabbis are the sole authorities for interpreting the Bible. Karaites believe that every Jew has the obligation to study the Torah and decide for him/herself the correct interpretation of YHWH's (God's) commandments, since in the end it is the individual, not the central authority, who is responsible for his own actions. This principle was expressed best by Anan ben David Hanasi, one of Karaism's great leaders, who said “Search the Scripture well and do not rely on my opinion.”¹ Karaites *do not reject all interpretation and do not take the Bible literally* since everything requires interpretation. Instead, Karaites require every interpretation to stand up to the same objective scrutiny regardless of its source.

History of Karaism

Karaism has been around since God gave his laws to the Jewish people. At first those who followed YHWH's laws were merely called “Righteous” and it was only in the 9th century CE that they came to be called Karaites. The question of why God's followers are today called Karaites is really a question of the origin of the other sects. At first there was no reason to label the “Righteous” as a separate sect because there was only the one

¹ It does not say to reject the opinion of the learned. It simply warns against relying solely on an opinion without verifying its merits in light of the Tanach.

sect, which consisted of the whole Jewish people. Throughout history, the "Righteous" took on such names as Sadducees, Boethusians, Ananites, and Karaites, so as to distinguish themselves from a variety of sects that appeared.

Biblical Period- The Righteous

In the Biblical Period people are described as falling into two categories: the sinners and the righteous. Very often false prophets who claimed to be relaying the message of God led the people into sin. In some periods the majority of Israel followed these false prophets and those who remained loyal to YHWH were but a small few (e.g. Elijah at Mt. Carmel). God sent his prophets "from morning until evening" calling on the people to repent but all too often it was only by punishing the nation with a great calamity that YHWH could get them to listen. Much of Biblical history is a repeating of the familiar cycle of sin, punishment, repentance and rescue.

Second Temple period- The Sadducees and Boethusians

The first reference in the history of Israel to more than one sect takes place some 200 years after the close of the Biblical period, in the first century BCE. Various sources tell us of two opposing sects, the Sadducees (Zadokites) and the Pharisees. The Sadducees followed the Torah as it was written while the Pharisees believed in a second "Oral" Torah, which they added to the written one. The Second Temple period saw the rise of several more sects, among them another group which only followed the written Torah called the Boethusians and a sect which added several books to the Bible called the Essenes (a.k.a. the "Dead Sea Sect").

Like the Karaites who were to follow them, the Sadducees and the Boethusians continued the tradition originated by Moses of keeping the Torah's commandments with no addition (Deuteronomy 4:2). We often hear in ancient literature that the Sadducees denied the doctrines of the immortality of the soul and reward and punishment in the hereafter. Whether this is accurate or not is of little consequence since they arrived at these beliefs

based on an honest interpretation of the Bible (even if most Karaites disagree with them on these doctrines). The Pharisees on the other hand believed that the interpretation of a particular teacher was divine and elevated these teachings to the level of the Torah itself. After time this doctrine got carried away and they claimed that these teachings originated from God himself in the form of a second, "Oral" Torah. They even went so far as to claim that when two teachers taught diametrically opposite interpretations of the Bible that both interpretations were from God.² The third major sect, the Essenes, had a Bible that consisted of more than our 24 Books and as a result had practices that do not originate in our Bible such as a solar calendar.

How long these three sects continued to co-exist is unknown. It is often thought that the Essenes and Sadducees ceased to exist with the destruction of the Temple in 70 CE. However this seems unlikely as writings of the Essenes appear as late as the 10th century, which seems to indicate that they survived well after the destruction of the Temple. References to the Sadducees and the Boethusians continue to appear in post-70 CE literature and they also seemed to have survived for some time.

Middle Ages- The Ananites and the Karaites

In the early middle-ages the Pharisees continued to thrive. They began to call themselves Rabbis and only used the name Pharisees when remembering historical events from the Second Temple period. In the 7th century, the Islamic Empire swept the Middle-east. The Muslims had no interest in imposing Islamic religious practice on the Jews and gave them a degree of autonomy under a system known as the Exilarchate. The Exilarchate had been founded hundreds of years earlier under

² "Rabbi Aba said in the name of Samuel: Three years were the House of Shammai and the House of Hillel divided. These said the law is according to us and those said the law is according to us. An angelic voice went out and said 'Both these and those are the words of the living God.'" (Talmud Babli, Erubin 13b) In Rabbinic theology this alleged incident was cited as proof of the general rule that when two Rabbis argue, both opposing opinions are "the words of the living God".

Sassanian rule but until now only had influence in Babylonia and Persia. Overnight the Rabbanites turned from a localized Babylonian phenomenon into a political power that stretched throughout much of the Middle-east. From the 3rd-5th centuries the Babylonian Rabbanites had developed a body of religious law known as the Babylonian Talmud, which they now imposed on every Jew in the Empire.

Resistance to the Rabbanites was fierce, especially in the Empire's eastern provinces, which had never even heard of the Talmud. The historians tell us of Jewish leaders whose resistance against the Talmud put them in direct conflict with the Islamic government, which had empowered the Rabbis and given them authority over other Jews. One resistance leader who refused to accept the Talmud was named Abu Isa al-Isfahani and it is said that he led an army of Jews against the Muslim government. Other attempts to cast off the Talmud were also undertaken but all failed and the Rabbanites and their Talmud seemed unstoppable.

Then in the 8th century a last glimmer of hope appeared in the form of a shrewd leader named Anan ben David. Anan organized various anti-Talmudic elements and lobbied the Muslim Caliphate to establish a second Exilarchate for those who rejected the Talmud. The Muslims granted Anan and his followers the religious freedom to practice Judaism in their own way. Anan gathered a large following around him and his followers became known as the Ananites. Some time after Anan's death his followers merged with other Tanach-only groups and took on the name "Followers of the Bible" or in Hebrew "Bnei Mikra". Later "Bnei Mikra" was abbreviated into "Kara'im" or in English "Karaites".

The Psychological Dependence on the “Oral Law”

It is a common Rabbinic claim that the Torah is but a skeleton-frame of the Jewish faith. Being the skeleton, they further claim, it needs flesh and blood to make it vibrant and living. The Rabbis have found this vibrancy in the form of their “Oral Law.” A careful investigation, however, demonstrates that the Rabbinic “Oral Law” is not the flesh and blood that the Torah is missing, but rather the by-product of a failure to search the Scriptures for their true meaning. In the absence of such a search, the Talmud often comes to erroneous conclusions about the Biblical text. The greatest shame is that most Jews are told that the Torah is an incomplete document and must be supplemented with this Oral accompaniment, and this despite the clear teaching in the Tanach itself that “The Torah of YHWH is perfect” (Psalms 19:8).³ Thus, those students genuinely interested in reaching the true meaning of a passage become psychologically dependent on an “Oral Law.” They feel the answers are not contained within the Tanach itself and therefore do not undertake the necessary steps to find them within the Tanach. The need for an “Oral Law” to interpret the commandments then becomes self-reinforcing, never allowing one to search the Bible itself for the answers. Be assured, however, that most of the meaning of the commandments and principles can be determined from an honest and thorough investigation of the text. That which cannot be determined is the result of our inability to recover the plain meaning of the text, which would have been available to the average Israelite receiving the Torah.⁴

³ The word translated as “perfect” also has the meaning of “complete.”

⁴ The loss of Biblical Hebrew is a contributing factor to this phenomenon. Often times, one needs to reconstruct the meaning of a passage by looking at similar phrases throughout the rest of the Tanach.

Search the Scripture Well

The fundamental tenet of Karaism is thus: “Search the Scripture well and do not rely on my opinion.” Since in the end, we are accountable for our own decisions and actions, it is important that we each look into the religious issues that concern our daily lives. While it is encouraged to seek the opinion of others, it is imperative that we not accept those opinions without verifying that they make sense in the context of the Biblical narrative. Even the interpretations of this work should be checked to make sure they are consistent with the message of the Tanach. An open mind and a motivated researcher, working with the correct tools, will gradually understand the intricacies of the Hebrew Bible and will be able to decide independently what the correct interpretations are.

Logical Reasons Karaites Reject the “Oral Law”

Before examining textual reasons why Karaites solely believe in the written Torah, it is important to understand logical reasons why.

- 1) Throughout the Hebrew Bible, the word Torah (in the sense of the body/corpus of Divine Instruction) is always used in the singular. Were the Mishnah⁵ a genuine (oral) Torah, surely somewhere in the Scriptures the existence of two Torot (Torahs) would have been mentioned at least once. On the other hand the Rabbanites specifically claim that there are two Torahs, the Written Torah and

the Oral Torah.⁶ Yet the term Torah, when meaning “collection of divine instruction,” never appears in the plural in the entire Tanach. All we read about in the Tanach is a singular Torah of Moses, never the Torahs of Moses.

- 2) Throughout the six divisions of the Mishnah there is a lack of the Biblical formula, “And YHWH spoke to Moses and Aaron,” instead in the Mishnah it is written, “Rabbi so-and-so said to Rabbi so-and-so.” The Mishnah is thus clearly the words of men.
- 3) The Tanach reports that the written Torah was both lost and forgotten for over 50 years and only rediscovered by the Temple priests (2Ki 22:8; 2Chr 34:15). It is inconceivable that an oral Law could have been remembered when even the written Law was forgotten—especially since the “Oral Law” is dependent on the Written Law to derive its full meaning.
- 4) The Rabbis claim that the “Oral Law” was given on Mount Sinai as the official interpretation of the Torah. Yet if one actually looks at the Mishnah and Talmud they are full of the opinions of Rabbis who disagree with each other on almost every issue. The Rabbis explain that whenever there are such disagreements, “both opinions are the words of the living God.” While it is possible for two learned individuals to reach differing binding conclusions, reason dictates that at least one of them is wrong. Karaites maintain that it is unreasonable to believe that God would consistently contradict Himself.
- 5) The Rabbis contend that the “Oral Law” was given to Moses at Mt. Sinai. This is hard to believe since the

⁵ The Talmud is divided up into two parts— the Mishnah and the Gemarah. The Mishnah is the “Oral Law” and the Gemarah is a commentary on the Mishnah.

⁶ “Our Rabbis taught: A certain heathen once came before Shammai and asked him, ‘How many Torahs have you?’ ‘Two,’ he replied: ‘the Written Torah and the Oral Torah.’” (Talmud Babli, Sabbath 31a)

Torah itself was not given in its entirety to Moses and the Israelites at Mt. Sinai. Rather, it was given to the Israelites in a series of revelations over a period of 40 years in the desert. Each revelation took a form similar to that in the following verse: “And YHWH spoke unto Moses in the wilderness of Sinai in the second year of their going out from the land of Egypt in the first month saying. . .” (Numbers 9:1). If the Rabbis are correct this means that Moses learned the “Oral Law” and its explanation of key verses *before* he learned these key verses!

Textual Reasons Karaites Reject the “Oral Law”

The logical objections to the “Oral Law” would be meaningless if they were not supported by sound textual evidence. Below are a few of the many examples that demonstrate that the Written Law stands alone as God’s instruction to the Israelites:

- 1) Then YHWH, Your God, will make you most prosperous. . . for YHWH will again rejoice over you for good, as He rejoiced over your fathers; if you shall hearken to the voice of YHWH your God, to keep his *commandments which are written* in this book of the Torah. (Deuteronomy 30:9-10)
- 2) And Moses *wrote this Law*, and delivered it unto the priests, sons of Levi... (Deuteronomy 31:9)
- 3) When all Israel is come to appear before your God in the place which he shall choose you shall *read this Law* before all Israel in their hearing. (Deuteronomy 31:11)
- 4) This book of the Law (Torah) shall not depart out of your mouth; but you shall meditate therein day

and night, that you may observe to do according to all that is *written* therein. (Joshua 1:8)

- 5) After that, *he read all the words of the Law*, the Blessing and the Curse, *just as is written in the Book of the Law*. There was not a word of all that Moses had commanded which Joshua failed to read in the presence of the entire assembly of Israel, including the women and children and the strangers who accompanied them. (Joshua 8:34-35)

This last verse could stand alone in summing up the entire Karaite argument. It explicitly states that Joshua read every single word that Moses commanded. To “read” something implies it is written down. In this case, the verse indicates that he read the text “just as is written.” Had Moses given the Israelites a second “Oral” Torah, Joshua would not have been able to “read” all the words that Moses had commanded. Furthermore, Verse 1 states that the only thing we need to do for YHWH to rejoice over us is to follow the written commandments. This negates the importance of an alleged “Oral Law.” For God would not give an “Oral Law,” which as the Rabbis claim is religiously binding, and then negate its importance.

Collectively these verses show that the Israelites received one law from YHWH, all of the words of the law were written so that they may be read allowed and followed by the nation of Israel to gain favor with YHWH.

Talmudic Claims and the Karaite Responses

In discussing this issue with students of the Talmud, one will invariably encounter many standard Rabbinic claims about verses that they believe allude to the “Oral Law” or at the very least need an oral accompaniment that explains the verse. If these verses are looked at in the context of the entire Hebrew Bible,

however, one will find that these verses really do not make reference to the “Oral Law,” nor do they cry out for an oral law for their understanding.

Claim #1:

“We are told to slaughter animals as God has commanded, yet nowhere in the entire Tanach does God tell us how to slaughter the animals.”

Response:

To attempt to prove the existence of the “Oral Law” the students of the Talmud often quote Deuteronomy 12:21, which states, “. . . then thou shalt kill of thy herd and thy flock, which YHWH has given thee, *as I have commanded thee*. . .” The Rabbis claim that the phrase “as I have commanded thee” refers to the parts of the “Oral Law” which explain the proper methods of slaughtering an animal. Indeed there are many requirements laid down in the Talmud as to the “proper” way of killing an animal; however, these are the customs of those writing the Talmud rather than the laws of God. The most misleading aspect of the claim that this passage refers to an alleged oral law is that it ignores the context of the passage. For not more than 5 verses earlier we see that the Torah itself dictates how we are to slaughter animals: “According to all the desire of your soul may you slaughter and eat meat... only you may not eat the blood, you must spill it on the ground like water.” (Deuteronomy 12:15-16). From this, we learn that to properly slaughter an animal we must do it in a manner that pours its blood on the ground- as opposed to letting it harden in the veins of the slaughtered animal. This reading is confirmed by the lines directly succeeding the very verse in question: “Only be sure that thou eat not the blood: for the blood is the life; and thou may not eat the life with the meat. . .” (Deuteronomy 12:23). In fact, this verse states that the only requirement of slaughter in the context of this passage is that we do not eat the blood. By slaughtering an animal so that its blood leaves its veins, as God has commanded, we avoid consuming the blood of the animal, thus following the commandment laid out in Deuteronomy 12:15-16.

Claim #2:

“There are in fact places where the word Torah is used in its plural form (Torot), so how can Karaites claim that there is no reference to two Torahs within the Bible?”

Response:

While the word *torah* does appear in its plural form throughout the Hebrew Bible, the term Torah, in the sense of the collective body of laws given by God, is only used in the singular. Compare the following verses to see the difference between the use of the word in the sense of a specific commandment and the use of the word in the sense of the collection of divine laws.

Verse Type 1: The word *torah* is used in the singular to refer to the Torah, the collective instruction of God: “And Moses wrote *this Law* (Torah), and delivered it unto the priests, sons of Levi...” (Deuteronomy 31:9).

Here the word *torah*, which is translated as “law,” refers to the complete works that God commanded Moses to write down. The term *torah* is never used in the plural when found in Type 1 verses. For more verses of this type, see *Textual Reasons Karaites Reject the “Oral Law.”*

Verse Type 2: The singular of *torah* is used in a meaning other than that referring to the Torah as a whole: “And this is the torah [instruction] of the Nazir, on the day of fulfillment of his days of consecration; he shall be brought to the opening of the Tent of Appointed-Times.” (Numbers 6:13)

It is apparent here that even though the word *torah* is used in the singular it does not refer to the *collective* Instruction of God, i.e. it does not refer to the Torah. Type 2 verses refer to specific laws such as those regarding animals, individuals, or groups. For more verses of this type, see Numbers 5:29-31, Leviticus 7:1, and Leviticus 11:46-47.

Verse Type 3: The plural of *torah* is used in a meaning other than that relating to the Torah as a whole: "These are the statutes, the ordinances, and the teachings (v'hatorot) that YHWH gave between Himself and the children of Israel on Mount Sinai, by the hand of Moses." (Lev. 26:46)

Here the word *torah* is used in its plural form; however, this "*torah*" is qualitatively different from the *torah* in type 1 verses, i.e. it does not refer to the Torah. We see that this verse uses the word *torah* to mean general instructions or teachings contained in the Torah. We understand this from its context since it is used with the words "ordinances" and "statutes" which also refer to items contained in the Torah. All verses that refer to the plural of *torah* are of this type. Furthermore, it says that these teachings (*torot*) were written in that they came to us by the hand of Moses. Thus this cannot be referring to the "Oral Law." For other verses of this type see Exodus 18:20 and Nehemiah 9:13.

To summarize, the term *torah* means "teaching, law". It can refer to a specific law, as in "This is the *torah* of the guilt-offering" (Leviticus 7:1), or it can refer to the collective body of divine law, as in "the Book of the Torah of Moses" (Joshua 8:31). When it appears in the plural as "*torot*," it is always in a series of words for specific laws: "And he gave them right judgments and true *torahs* and good statutes and commandments." (Nehemiah 9:13). Obviously in this last verse the word *torah* is a synonym for commandment, statute, etc., and refers to specific laws, not the *collective* body of divine instruction. For the people to interpret this verse as a reference to the "Oral Law" they would also have to argue that "statutes and commandments" refer to multiple bodies of law (at least 4 since both are plural!). These verses only make sense if all of these terms refer to different words for specific laws.

Claim #3:

"In the Book of Daniel we see that Daniel prayed three times a day facing Jerusalem. This is something he learned from the "Oral Law" since it is not commanded in the Torah."

Response:

Indeed, Daniel 6:11 states "now he had windows open in his chamber toward Jerusalem, and he kneeled upon his knees three times a day, and prayed, and gave thanks before his God. . ." A common claim of students of the Rabbinic movement is that since the Torah does not tell us to pray toward Jerusalem or how many times a day we should pray, these things could only have been learned from the 'Oral law.'"

This claim illustrates a significant difference between Karaites and Rabbanites. Karaites believe that every word and example in the Tanach is there for a reason and Karaites therefore use the entire Tanach to derive religious principles and the meaning of commandments, while Rabbanites generally rely solely on the Torah and Talmud. It is true that the Torah does not mention that we need to face Jerusalem when we pray, but the concept comes from Solomon's dedication of the First Temple.

Presumably speaking under divine inspiration, Solomon says that when we are captive in a foreign land or are doing God's work in a foreign land we may pray toward Jerusalem so that God will maintain our cause. Solomon declares,

If your people go out to battle against their enemy, by whatever way You [God] shall send them, and they *pray to YHWH toward the city You have chosen*, and toward the house which I have built for Your name; then hear in heaven their prayers and their supplication and maintain their cause. (1 Kings 8:44)

As a result, all Jews outside Jerusalem pray toward Jerusalem. This idea is also illustrated in Psalms 138:2: "I will bow down toward thy holy Temple. . ."

As to the number of daily prayers, there are many good choices. Daniel chose to pray three times daily, whereas the person who wrote Psalms 119 prayed to God seven times a day (Psalms 119:164 and 169-176). From this we learn that the number of times a

person may pray to God daily is up to the individual. Today, since prayers are a substitute for sacrifices (see Hosea 14:3; Psalms 141:2), we should pray at least twice a day Sunday through Friday and three times a day on Saturday. For there were two sacrifices offered daily and a special Sabbath sacrifice offered on Shabbat.

Finally, the book of Daniel illustrates one more point worth noting. When praying, Daniel fully prostrated (i.e. he prayed on his knees). In Biblical times full prostration was almost synonymous with prayer (see also Psalms 95:6 and Psalms 138:2). In Eastern lands up until the late Medieval Period Rabbanites prayed with full prostration. Today, in very Orthodox Rabbanite Congregations on Yom Kippur the entire congregation will fully prostrate. To this day, Karaites fully prostrate in all of their prayers.

Karaite Exegesis: A Practical Example

Tefillin and Mezuzot

Biblical exegesis refers to the explanation or critical analysis/interpretation of the Bible. Karaism interprets the Bible in a manner that weighs all the biblical evidence available. As has been alluded to throughout, Karaites do not take the Bible literally. One such example concerns the verses in the Bible surrounding the Rabbanite *Tefillin*. These verses read as follows:

- And it shall be for you for a sign upon your hand and a *Zicharon* between your eyes. (Exodus 13:9)
- And it shall be for a sign upon your hand and *Totafot* between your eyes. (Exodus 13:16)
- And you shall tie them for a sign upon your hand and they will be for *Totafot* between your eyes. (Deuteronomy 6:8)

- And you shall tie them for a sign upon your hand and they will be for *Totafot* between your eyes. (Deuteronomy 11:18)

We see that in one of the four “*Tefillin* passages” the word *Totafot* (which the Rabbis have arbitrarily translated as “frontlets”) is replaced with the word *Zicharon*. The word *Zicharon* means “remembrance” or “reminder” and indicates that we should remember to keep the words of God *as if* they were placed between our eyes. This is the understanding that was undoubtedly available to the ancient Israelites. For we see the metaphorical use of similar phrases throughout the Tanach. For example, just as the Tanach states to write the words commanded to us upon our doorposts (Deut 6:9), it also says to write them on the tablets of our hearts (Proverbs 7:3). Since the meaning to write them on the tablets of our hearts is obviously metaphorical, we should also conclude that the commandment to write them on the doorposts of our house is metaphorical as well. In both cases, taking the verse “literally” would require the impossible act of writing out much of the Torah on a tiny space.⁷

In the following verses note how the Israelites used phrases similar to those in the “*Tefillin passages*” to denote clearly metaphorical images:

- Listen my son to the teaching of your father and do not abandon the Torah of your mother; because it is a beautiful wreath for your head and a necklace upon your throat. (Proverbs 1:8-9)

⁷ No mention is made of only writing a few paragraphs. On the contrary, reference is made to “these words which I command you this day”, referring to Moses’ long exhortatory speech spanning Deuteronomy 1-30.

- Do not let truth and righteousness leave you; tie them upon your throat, write them upon the tablet of your heart. (Proverbs 3:3)
- Keep my son the Mitzvot of your father and do not abandon the Torah of your mother; Tie them upon your heart always, don them upon your throat. (Proverbs 6:20-21)
- Keep my commandments and live, and my Torah as the pupil of your eye. Bind them on your finger, write them upon the tablet of your heart. (Proverbs 7:3)
- I will place my Torah in their inward parts and upon their hearts I will write it. (Jeremiah 31:32)

Furthermore, the passages themselves in which the so-called *Tefillin* verses occur employ a whole series of metaphorical devices. For it says, "... that the Torah of YHWH may be in your mouth" (Exodus 13:9) and "you shall place these words which I command you upon your hearts and upon your souls" (Deuteronomy 11:18). Keeping in mind the context of the "*Tefillin passages*" and the verses above, it seems appropriate to translate them as follows:

- And it shall be for you for a sign upon your hand and a remembrance (*Zicharon*) between your eyes. (Exodus 13:9)
- And it shall be for a sign upon your hand and a remembrance (*Totafot*⁸) between your eyes. (Exodus 13:16)

⁸ The singular of the word "*Totaphot*" is used in Mishnaic Hebrew to refer to a type of headress or tiara. Some have connected the word *Totaphot* with the Hebrew word *Netipha*, which means drop-shaped pendant, while most concordances have connected it to a seldom used Hebrew root meaning "surround." All three of these possibilities further emphasize the metaphorical meaning of the passage.

- And you shall tie them for a sign upon your hand and they will be for a remembrance (*Totafot*) between your eyes. (Deuteronomy 6:8)
- And you shall tie them for a sign upon your hand and they will be for a remembrance (*Totafot*) between your eyes. (Deuteronomy 11:18)

The conclusion that Karaites reach from this analysis is that there was never any commandment to wear *Tefillin* or put *Mezuzot* on their doors. These verses simply illustrate the importance of always being mindful of the commandments so that we may follow them.

Frequently Asked Questions

1) *Do Karaites believe that everything contained in the Talmud is wrong?*

No: To argue that every interpretation contained in the Talmud is wrong would be the same as arguing that a view is wrong simply because it is possessed by Karaites. This is not a fair means of debate, nor is it conducive to finding the truth behind some of the more pertinent issues in the Tanach. When evaluating an interpretation, one must evaluate the interpretation rather than the person who holds the interpretation. In this case, it is fair to say that we should look at the message and not the messenger. On the other hand, to read the Talmud and regard it as the final word on the issues at hand is unacceptable- especially since the Talmud often reaches conclusions devoid of biblical support.

2) *How is it that Karaites can disagree with the interpretations of the thousands of Rabbis who have read the Bible and with the words of the Talmud which have stood the test of time?*

The number of Karaites or Rabbanites who hold any opinion is not of significance if the opinion is wrong. A similar question can be asked as to why the Jews would choose not to accept Jesus when so many Christians do. Surely, no Rabbi would change his beliefs simply because Christians far outnumber the Jews in the world population. Furthermore, a text is not self-justified. Its ability to survive the test of time is usually not a good indication that one should extract life's guiding principles from it. The fact that the Talmud has been with Rabbinic Judaism for a long time should not convince anyone of its authenticity as the word of God. The Christian New Testament has survived for 1900 years and is even older than the Talmud! Yet no Rabbi would accept it as "truth" just because it has endured for so many centuries.

3) *Are Karaites considered Jews?*

Yes: Karaites believe in one God, the divinity of the 24 books of the Hebrew Bible, and the coming of a Messiah. Karaites are recognized as Jews by the state of Israel. Furthermore, every Israeli has an identity card and on this identity card is registered the holder's religious/ethnic affiliation. The identity card belonging to a Karaite has "Jewish" in the space for their religious/ethnic affiliation. Karaites are also covered under the Israeli Right of Return- the right of all Jews anywhere to return to Israel and seek immediate citizenship. Recently the government of Israel published a stamp in honor of the Karaite Jews.

Adamant followers of the Rabbinic tradition, however, will argue that Karaites are not Jews. There are two reasons they hold this claim. One is simply that Karaites do not follow the "laws" of the Rabbis. The other is that Karaites throughout history have tended to follow the Biblical model by recognizing patrilineal descent- the belief that one's status as a Jew (or more specifically as an Israelite) is passed on

through the father. The Rabbis, on the other hand, have recognized matrilineal descent- the belief that one is Jewish only if his/her mother is Jewish. Therefore, if a Karaite man married a non-Jewish woman, the Rabbis would not have considered the child Jewish while Karaites would have considered the child Jewish.⁹

Both of the assertions given by the Rabbis are unfortunate reasons to claim that Karaites are not Jews. Karaites generally consider Rabbanites Jews and instead of focusing on debates over whether Rabbanites are Jewish, Karaites place their attention on reaching the correct understanding of the commandments in the Torah. The same divisiveness that the Orthodox use to say that Karaites are not Jews has also lead to great strife within the Rabbinic movement with the Orthodox refusing to recognize the Reform or even the Conservatives as Jews. For the Jewish movement to move forward toward a path of unity and understanding of the Torah, we must not resort to excluding each other from calling ourselves "Jews." Instead we must allow free debate on topics so that we can attempt to reach common ground, wherever possible, on the issues that affect our everyday observance as Jews.

Regardless of what a certain Karaite, Rabbanite, or political authority might claim about who is Jewish, the Biblical model suggests that anyone who 1) is circumcised [males only], 2) accepts the God of Israel as his/her own God, and 3) accepts the People of Israel as his/her own people is a full-fledged Jew [Israelite]. (See Exodus 12:43-49 and Ruth 1:16.)

⁹ Conversely, if a Rabbanite woman married a non-Jewish man, some Karaites would not regard their children as Jewish.

4) *Do Karaites follow the Bible literally?*

No: As addressed in the opening passages, every word of the Torah (and even the entire Hebrew Bible) is subject to interpretation. This interpretation however must be consistent with the rest of the Bible and must also be consistent with the plain meaning of the text, which would have been available to the common Israelite receiving the Torah. In fact there are examples where it is the Rabbis who look for a “literal” interpretation of the commandments in places that Karaites have always understood a “metaphorical” meaning. (See *Karaite Exegesis: A Practical Example*)

We learn in Deuteronomy 31:12-13 that the Torah was to be read every seventh year before the entire congregation of Israel- men, women, and children. In an era in which written books were rare, this public reading was a primary source for learning the Torah. Therefore, we must assume that any interpretation that would not have been readily apparent to an ancient Israelite at this public reading cannot be what was intended. This requires us to bridge the gap of 3500 years in language and culture. To do this we must thoroughly study the Tanach by employing scientific methods of Hebrew linguistics and contextual exegesis.

5) *Don't Karaites have customs of their own?*

Yes, but they are just that- customs. Any Karaite who attempts to turn these customs into law is in violation of the Torah's commandment not to add or subtract to the word of God (Deuteronomy 4:2). The same is true for Rabbanites who turn Rabbinic customs into law.

6) *Since Karaites do not have Rabbis what title is given to those possessing knowledge of the Tanach?*

In Karaite tradition, such people are called Hakhamim (Wise Men/Women) or a Hakham/Hakhama (wise man/woman). The title of Hakham, unlike that of Rabbi or Priest, does not denote a clerical position, but rather indicates that one has reached a certain level of understanding in regards to the Tanach. To be a Hakham, one needs an in depth knowledge of linguistics, the intricacies of Biblical Hebrew, and must possess knowledge of the valid means for Biblical analysis.

Interestingly enough, while Orthodox Rabbanites do not permit females to become Rabbis, a female may become a Hakhama. In fact in the 10th century, long before modernism, the leader of the prominent and powerful Karaite community of Spain was a woman whom the Karaites referred to as “The Teacher [*al-Mualema*].”

7) *Isn't it true that Anan ben David (Hanasi) invented Karaism in 8th Century?*

As addressed in History of Karaism, there has always been a continuous history of Jews who did not believe in the Talmud. Anan simply gave them unified representation before the Muslim authorities. This brought about their freedom to practice the Judaism of their ancestors, which had previously been denied them under the persecution of the Rabbanite Exilarchs.

8) *Do Karaites light Shabbat Candles?*

No: Karaites have always believed that it is not permissible to burn any fires on Shabbat. Contrary to the Rabbinic blessing that states, “Blessed art thou, Lord, our God, King of the Universe who made us holy with His commandments and

commanded us to light Shabbat Candles,” no where in the written Torah or even in the Rabbinic “Oral Law” is there a commandment to light Shabbat Candles. The Torah thus prohibits this act. For it commands us not to add or subtract from the words of the Torah (cf. Deuteronomy 4:2). (For a technical analysis of this issue, please read Appendix A.)

The Biblical/Karaite Calendar

The Ripening of Barley and Setting of the New Year

The Bible indicates that the first month of the year occurs with the first new moon after the barley is ripe (Hebrew: *Abib*). This is called the month of “The Abib” and it is the month in which we left Egypt. On the 15th of this month commences Passover¹⁰ (Exodus 12:2, Exodus 13:4, Exodus 23:15).

In some years, we have to wait an extra lunar month (called a “leap month”) for the barley to ripen. The Rabbis, not having access to the land of Israel, developed a system to approximate the ripening of the barley. The Rabbis have adopted a 19 year cycle which sets every second or third year as a leap year, with seven leap years distributed throughout the 19 year cycle. On the other hand, up until the 18th century, the Karaites of Egypt, Syria, and Israel sent observers throughout the land of Israel to examine the state of the barley. Karaites who lived in countries that were far from the Land of Israel were unable to actually follow the Abib; however, they still recognized it as the true calendar. When the occasional traveler from the Middle East passed through these distant Karaite communities, they would question him regarding the Abib and adjust the holidays for that year accordingly. They also declared that as soon as their

¹⁰ The Biblical word Pesach, usually translated as Passover, refers exclusively to the Passover Sacrifice. The holiday, known in English as Passover, is referred to in the Bible as *Hag Hamatzot*- the Feast of Unleavened Bread. To avoid confusion, when referring to the holiday this work will use either the term “Passover” or “Feast of Unleavened Bread,” and will refer the sacrifice as the “Passover Sacrifice.”

communities be blessed with returning to the Land of Israel, they would immediately return to following the Abib.

Up until the 2nd century CE the Rabbanites in fact followed the Abib calendar. Although the Rabbanites supplemented the observance of the barley with their astronomical calculations of the equinox (which they learned from astrologers) and other non-Biblical factors- the use of which Karaites object to-, their writings, nevertheless, reveal that they recognized that the barley has special significance for intercalating the year. A Brayta (2nd century CE *Tanaitic* source) quoted in the Babylonian Talmud says as follows:

Our Rabbis taught, Based on three things is the year intercalated: on the Abib, on the fruits of the trees, and on the equinox. Based on two of them the year is intercalated but based on one of them alone the year is not intercalated. And when the Abib is one of them everyone is pleased. (Bavli Sanhedrin 11b)

Another Brayta relates:

Our Rabbis taught, The year is intercalated based on [the Abib in] three regions: Judea, Transjordan, and Galilee. Based on two of them the year is intercalated but based on one of them alone the year is not intercalated. And when Judea is one of them everyone is pleased because the Omer Offering [Elevation-Offering of Barley] can only come from Judea. (Bavli Sanhedrin 11b)

Thus even Rabbinic literature emphasizes the importance of the ripening of the barley in determining the start New Year.

The New Moon

One characteristic of observant Karaites has always been their following the Biblical practice of using the physical sighting of the moon to declare new months and set the dates of holidays. Originally the Rabbanites also followed this calendar and it is discussed at length in the Talmud (see *Mishnah Rosh Hashanah*). The Rabbanites continued to follow New Moon observations until at least the 2nd Century CE, but gradually replaced them with primitive¹¹ calculations intended to approximate the lunar cycle. In contrast, the Karaites remained loyal to the true Biblical calendar and continued to follow new moon observations throughout the Middle Ages. The Karaite commitment to the Biblical calendar was so ingrained in their consciousness that a solemn oath was incorporated into their wedding ceremony "to keep the Holy appointed times according to the visibility of the New Moon and the finding of the Abib (ripen ears of barley) in the Land of Israel". Similarly, on High Holidays the Karaite congregation would declare the truth of the New Moon-Abib calendar.

The Bible clearly indicates that the moon dictates the Biblical calendar. Evidence of this comes from Psalm 104:19 in which it states, "He created the moon for Mo'adim [appointed times]." Keeping the holidays at their correct time is a direct commandment in the Torah, as it is written: "These are the Mo'adim [appointed times] of YHWH, holy convocations which you shall proclaim in their appointed times [Mo'adam]" (Leviticus 23:4). During most Karaite holiday services, this verse is read aloud by the *hazzan* and repeated by the entire congregation to express the Karaite adherence to this clear biblical injunction.

At a time when Israelites did not have daily access to the Land of Israel, the Rabbis developed a system to calculate approximate new moon sightings. Today, though, now that we have access to the Land of Israel, we are able to gather new moon sightings

¹¹ Today much more accurate predictions are available.

from various places throughout Israel. These new moon sightings reveal that the Rabbinic calculations for the calendar are often incorrect.

When asked why they do not change their observance to follow the actual new moon sightings, the Rabbis often respond that only the Sanhedrin¹² can declare a new moon¹³. Since today we do not have the Sanhedrin, they further claim, we must follow the Rabbinic calculations that have predicted the new moons. This is the idea presented in the following article of the Chabad Jewish movement regarding the start of Passover:

...were there a Sanhedrin today, the upcoming New Moon Day of Nisan would not fall out on Sunday [March 25, 2001], but rather on Tuesday [March 27, 2001], since the earliest possible occasion to sight the New Moon will be on Monday [night].
(From an interview with New Moon expert Dr. Roy Hoffman of Hebrew University of Jerusalem in Tse'irei Chabad [Chabad Youth Movement], Sichat Hashavua, Parashat Vayakhel-Pekudei, 5761 [Issue No. 742] p.4)

Interestingly enough, Dr. Hoffman was correct and the new moon was seen on Monday night as he (and the Karaites) predicted. Thus, observant Karaites celebrated the beginning of Passover on Monday night, while the Rabbanites celebrated it on Saturday night- two days earlier. The implications of this are serious in that on the last days of Passover based on the visibility of the moon, the Rabbanites were eating leavened bread! It is for

¹² The Sanhedrin was a council of elders in ancient Israel.

¹³ Ironically, the Rabbis claim that only the Sanhedrin can declare a new moon, when at the same time it is they who have instituted a system that arbitrarily (and often erroneously) declares new moons.

this reason that Karaites cannot adopt the Rabbinic calendar and must continue to use the new moon observations.¹⁴

While the Rabbanite calendar served a need for the Jewish communities far from Israel at a time when the Jews were exiled from Israel, we should now, since we have access to the Land of Israel, return to the physical observance of the barley and the moon.

Shavuot

Another significant issue that divides the Rabbanite and Karaite/Biblical calendar is the placement of Shavuot- The Feast of Weeks. God instructed us to count 50 days (with Shavuot being the 50th day) from the time of Passover. Both Karaites and Rabbanites agree upon this point. They disagree as to when to when the counting actually starts. The Torah states the following:

And you shall count from the morrow after the Sabbath [Hebrew: *Shabbat*] from the day you bring the Omer [Sheaf] of Waving; seven complete Sabbaths [Hebrew: *Shabbatot*] shall you count... until the morrow of the seventh Sabbath [Hebrew: *Shabbat*] you will count fifty days... and you shall proclaim on this very day, it shall be a holy convocation for you " (Lev 23:15-16, 21).

Karaites believe that the Sabbath referred to in the first line is the Shabbat (Friday night until Saturday night) that concludes the week. They believe that the counting of the fifty days until Shavuot starts on the first Sunday during Passover, i.e. the morrow after the Sabbath.¹⁵ The Rabbis and the Pharisees before

¹⁴ Even though Karaites wait for the physical new moon to determine their holidays, it is known with a very high degree of certainty when the new moon will be visible on most months, making it easy to prepare for the holidays in advance.

¹⁵ If the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread begins on a Saturday night as it does in book of Joshua, then the counting begins on this day. (Compare Joshua 5:11 and Leviticus 23:14)

them believe that the word "Sabbath" in the first line refers to the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread, whereas the word "Sabbath" in the other lines is to be translated as weeks. Thus by the Rabbinic counting, Shavuot always falls out on the 6th of Sivan which is 50 days after the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread. For Rabbanites the day of the week upon which Shavuot falls varies from year to year. On the other hand, Karaites always celebrate Shavuot on a Sunday, since this is the day after the seventh Sabbath. For Karaites the date of Shavuot varies from year to year.

Below are classic Karaite arguments about the placing of Shavuot:

1) Shavuot is the only holiday in the Hebrew Bible not given a date. Instead we are commanded to count off the days until Shavuot. Had God wanted us to celebrate Shavuot on the same date every year, it would have been commanded in the Torah that we celebrate Shavuot on such-and-such date, just as it was for every other holiday. It only makes sense that no date was given for Shavuot if the date varies every year due to counting off a specified period of time from a non-fixed starting point.

2) The Rabbinic interpretation requires that the first appearance of the word "Sabbath" refer to the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread. While it could theoretically be referring to the first day of Passover, since work is forbidden on this day, the Torah never describes this day as a "Sabbath," as it does regarding Yom Kippur, nor does it even describe it as a "Shabbaton;" as it refers to Yom Teruah, the first day of Succot, and Shemini Atzeret (the day after the seventh day of Succot). Furthermore, if we start counting from the first day of Passover, the 50th day would not be "the morrow after the seventh Sabbath" (Leviticus 23:16), since the 49th day is not a Sabbath nor is it a day of rest,

even by Rabbinic tradition, unless the 49th day falls on Shabbat.

Additionally, the Scripture says "the Morrow after **the** Sabbath" with the definite article, indicating that the Scripture means the Sabbath of Genesis as it is written only a few verses earlier, "**it** [the 7th Day] is a Sabbath to YHWH in all your habitations" (Leviticus 23:3). If the Scripture had intended a day other than that generally known as the Sabbath, it would have mentioned it specifically.

- 3) To get around the argument above, the Rabbis translate the first appearance of the word "Sabbath" as "holiday"-claiming it refers to the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread - and the second and third occurrences of "Sabbath" as "week." Thus they translate the verse as:

And you shall count from the morrow after the holiday (Hebrew: *Shabbat*) from the day you bring the Omer [Sheaf] of Waving; seven complete weeks (Hebrew: *Shabbatot*) shall you count... until the morrow of the seventh week (Hebrew: *Shabbat*) you will count fifty days... and you shall proclaim on this very day, it shall be a holy convocation for you. (Leviticus 23,15-16,21)

If this is the correct translation/interpretation, as the Rabbanites claim, we find that in the first instance the meaning of "Sabbath" is "Holiday" and in the other two instances its meaning is a week which contains in it a Sabbath. This is interpretation is untenable. For the Torah mentioned "Sabbath" twice in the same breath and it would not have two different meanings unless the Scripture explicitly indicates that it does.

For these reasons, Karaites always celebrate Shavuot on a Sunday, on the 50th day starting with the Sunday that falls during the Passover Holiday.

Yom Teruah-The Rabbanite Rosh Hashanah

The Biblical/Karaite calendar also differs from the Rabbinic Calendar on the observance of the Jewish New Year. The Rabbanite calendar places the beginning of the year – "Rosh Hashanah"- on a holiday the Bible refers to as Yom Teruah (Day of Shouting), occurring on the first day of the Seventh month.¹⁶ As just discussed, Karaites celebrate the New Year in the month of the Feast of Unleavened Bread. For the Torah states: "This month will be for you the beginning of months; It is first of the months of the year" (Exodus 12:2). After this explicit statement, the Torah proceeds to describe the ceremony of the Passover Sacrifice which is to take place in this First month. Similarly, Leviticus 23 and Numbers 28 list the holidays and both passages describe the Passover Sacrifice in the First month and Yom Teruah in the Seventh month.

Karaites do not blow a Shofar on Yom Teruah. This is because there is no commandment to do so. According to Rabbinic tradition "Teruah" (Hebrew Root: טרע) refers to a sound that is created by a Shofar (Ram's Horn).¹⁷ However, the same root word (טרע) is used in Numbers 23:21 to signify shouting¹⁸ and in Numbers 10:5-6 where we are told to blow silver trumpets.

¹⁶ The Rabbis claim, however, that this date is not the New Year for the Jewish people but rather the New Year for the world. For some argue that this is the day on which the world was created. This however has no basis in the Tanach.

¹⁷ The Hebrew root טרע is indeed used in connection with a Shofar in Leviticus 25:9.

¹⁸ To shout to God in prayer is also expressed other places throughout the Tanach such as "Shout (Root: טרע) unto God with a singing voice!" (Psalm 47:2), which uses the same verbal root as "Teruah". Furthermore the verbal root in Teruah is also used to describe the sound of cymbals: "Praise him upon the loud cymbals: praise him upon the high sounding (Root: טרע) cymbals" (Psalm 150:5).

Interestingly, five verses later God commands us to sound¹⁹ the silver trumpets on the New Moon, i.e. first of every month (see Numbers 10:10). What is clear from all these verses is that the word Teruah, after which the day is named, is a general term for making a loud noise whether made by a Ram's horn, a silver trumpet, cymbals, or even a congregation praying to God.

Since a horn is sounded in the form of a trumpet on every first of the month, we must ask why Yom Teruah, the first day of the Seventh Month is set aside as a holy convocation. Unfortunately, the Torah itself does not tell us why this day is set aside as a Mo'ed (Appointed Time). However, since it is the start of the month in which both Yom Kippur and Succot occur, its importance becomes self evident. This appears to be a national day of preparation for the Israelites for the upcoming holidays. In an agricultural society, Succot, a holiday thanking God for the harvest and asking for a healthy harvest in the year to come, is of the utmost importance. Karaites have always used Yom Teruah as a national day of prayer to prepare for the upcoming holidays of the Seventh Month.

Karaite Exegesis: The Observance of Succot

The significance of Succot has just been emphasized in the context of Yom Teruah and Yom Kippur. Due to its importance, it is imperative to understand how to correctly celebrate this holiday. To acquire the correct understanding of how to celebrate this holiday requires a thorough search of the Tanach.

It states in Leviticus 23:40 to "take" on the first day of Succot the "fruit of a splendid tree [or, a splendid fruit tree], date palms, the branch of a thick tree and willows of the creek." Rabbinic tradition and law dictates that these four items- referred to as the Four Species- be carried in a bundle called a "Lulav"

and waived during a prayer service. Describing this bundle the Talmud states:

Rabbi Ishmael says: Three myrtle and two willow branches, one palm branch and one citron... Rabbi Akiva says: Just as there is only one palm branch and one citron, so too is there only one myrtle and one willow branch. (Mishnah Succot 3:4)

Here two prominent Rabbis argue over the exact specifications given by God at Mt. Sinai regarding how to construct the Lulav. Karaites point to such disagreements as proof that the words of the Talmud did not come from God but rather from men. For God would not consistently and overtly contradict himself.

While the Torah itself may be unclear to the modern reader as to what is supposed to be done with the items taken on the first day, clarification is given in later books of the Bible. In the book of Nehemiah, the Israelites rediscover for themselves the true meaning of the commandments regarding Succot:

And they found written in the Torah that YHWH commanded through Moses that the Children of Israel dwell in Booths (Succot) in the Seventh month. And concerning that which they heard [in the public reading] they passed a voice through all their cities and Jerusalem saying 'Go out to the mountain and bring olive branches and oil tree branches²⁰ and myrtle branches and date branches and branches of thick trees **to make booths, as it is written.**' And the people went out and they brought and they

²⁰ Many equate the "oil tree" [Hebrew: *Es Shemen*] mentioned here with the "pine tree." Further support for this comes from the fact that the Aramaic speaking Jews of northern Iraq called the pine, "*Es Shemen*."

¹⁹ The verbal root for "Teruah" is not used here.

made for themselves booths, each man on his roof and in their courtyards and in the courtyard of the House of God and in the broad areas of the Water Gate and the broad areas of Ephraim Gate. (Nehemiah 8:14-16)

Clearly according to the book of Nehemiah **the "four species" are to be used as materials for building a Succah**. Note that according to Nehemiah 8:15 the Torah requires that we use the "four species" to build a Succah, for the Book of Nehemiah states "it is written." In other words, when they read Leviticus 23:40 they understood it to be commanding the taking of the "four species" for the purpose of building Succot. Karaites have always accepted the interpretation of Nehemiah 8:14-16 over the contradictory interpretations laid out in the Talmud.

Conclusion

Whereas Karaite exegesis remains true to the Biblical text, searching for the meaning that would have been apparent to those receiving the Torah, Rabbanite exegesis holds holy the opinions and rulings of their Sages, even when those opinions depart from the Biblical standard. Karaites believe that the Hebrew Bible itself is the complete expression of the God of Israel. As seen in the examples of Karaite exegesis regarding Tefillin, the placing of the Biblical Holidays, and the observance of Succot, a diligent search throughout the Tanach is necessary before reaching any conclusions on the interpretations of the commandments. Even after a diligent search, we may be lacking the Biblical evidence to reach a convincing conclusion. For with the various calamities undergone by the Israelites throughout history, we have lost the plain meaning of the text. This search, however, is a necessity for those seeking to follow the commandments set down in the Torah. This is what is meant by Anan's phrase, "Search the scripture well. . ." This, quite simply, is the case for Karaism.

Appendix

Fires on Shabbat

Perhaps no issue between the Rabbanites and the Karaites has been so hotly contested as that of the permissibility of fires on Shabbat. Karaites have always maintained that no fire shall burn on Shabbat. While Rabbanites believe that a fire may burn on Shabbat if it has been kindled before the start of the Sabbath. The debate surrounds the following verse in the Torah: "Thou shall not kindle (from the Hebrew root: *Bi'er*; בִּיעַר)²¹ any fire throughout all your habitations on the Sabbath day" (Exodus 35:3).

The Hebrew verbal root *Bi'er* (בִּיעַר), translated above as *to kindle*, in fact has a broader meaning than its English counterpart. According to the *Random House Dictionary of the English Language*, the English verb *to kindle* signifies "to start (a fire), cause (a flame) to spring up." In other words, the English verb *to kindle* only denotes the first act of starting a fire. Once the fire catches and burns by itself, the originator of the fire is no longer said to be kindling it. In contrast, the Hebrew verb *Bi'er* signifies both the original act of starting the fire as well as any burning resulting from this original act and is better translated as "to kindle/cause to burn."

To be sure, the limited meaning of "to start a fire" is included in the Hebrew verb *Bi'er*, as is its use in the following verse: "The children gather wood, and the fathers kindle the fire..." (Jeremiah 7:18). However, unlike its English counterpart, the Hebrew verb *Bi'er* has a more encompassing meaning that also denotes the indirect act of causing a fire to burn. The full meaning of the

²¹ The Hebrew verb *Bi'er* appears in Ex 35:3 in the *Pi'el* form. The *Pi'el* form of the verb is what linguists call the "causative" sense. The "causative" sense is unique to Semitic languages, having no exact equivalent in English. As a result, *Bi'er* sometimes translates into English as "to light [a fire]" and other times as "to cause to burn".

Hebrew verb *Bi'er* can most clearly be seen in Judges 15:4-5, where we read of Samson's destruction of the fields of the Philistines:

"And Samson went and captured three hundred foxes, and took torches, attaching one tail to the other, and placed one torch between every two tails in the middle. And he lit (from *Bi'er*) the torches and he sent into the Philistine standing grain; and he caused to burn (from *Bi'er*) from stacked grain to standing grain and even olive groves."²²

We see that Samson lit torches that were carried by foxes into the fields of the Philistines. These torches burnt the fields, which in turn burnt the olive groves. Samson himself is said to have "kindled/caused to burn/burned" (from *Bi'er*) the fields and olive groves, even though all he did was light the torches and send the foxes into the fields. Thus we see that the Hebrew verb *Bi'er* applies to indirectly causing something to burn, even if the originator of the fire no longer has control of the fire. Put differently, in Hebrew when a person lights item A, which in turn lights item B, which then lights item C, the originator of the fire is said to have "kindled/caused to burn/burned" all three items.

This understanding is also evident in other parts of the Hebrew Bible. For example, there is a commandment in Exodus stating, "When a fire goes out and finds thorns, resulting in the

²² JPS Translation: "And Samson went and caught three hundred foxes, and took torches, and turned tail to tail, and put a torch in the midst between every two tails. (5) And when he had set the torches on fire (from *Bi'er*) he let them go into the standing corn of the Philistines, and burnt up (from *Bi'er*) both the shocks and the standing corn, and also the olive yards." KJV Translation: "And Samson went and caught three hundred foxes, and took firebrands, and turned tail to tail, and put a firebrand in the midst between two tails. And when he had set the brands on fire (from *Bi'er*), he let them go into the standing corn of the Philistines, and burnt up (from *Bi'er*) both the shocks, and also the standing corn, with the vineyards and olives."

consumption of stacks of grain, standing grain, or any field, he who caused the fire to burn (from *Bi'er*) shall surely pay" (Exodus 22:5 [6]).²³ The phrase "he who caused the fire to burn" is the translation of the single Hebrew word *Hamav'ir*²⁴ which derives from the root *Bi'er* - the same word used in the Sabbath prohibition. We see from this passage that the verbal root *Bi'er* has a broader meaning than just the act of starting a fire. Thus, when a fire is lit and that fire then burns thorns, which in turn burn a field, the original lighter of the fire is considered to have caused the field to burn and is legally responsible to pay for any destruction wreaked by that fire.

The example of Samson (Judges 15:4-5) and the passage regarding the burning of fires in fields (Exodus 22:5 [6]) demonstrate that according to the laws of the Bible the starter of a fire is responsible for the fire until it no longer burns. Similarly, if someone lights a fire before sunset on Friday evening and it burns into the Sabbath, that person is considered responsible for the burning of that flame on the Sabbath, regardless of when the burning was initiated. Since the verb *Bi'er* (בִּיעַר) is used in the Sabbath-fire prohibition (Exodus 35:3), as well as in these passages, one must conclude that causing a flame to burn on Shabbat is not permissible. For this reason, one might translate Exodus 35:3 as, "Thou shall not cause a flame to burn (from *Bi'er*; בִּיעַר) throughout all your habitations on the Sabbath Day."

Conversely, Rabbinic Judaism teaches that every Friday night we are commanded to light a flame in the form of Shabbat Candles. For that purpose, they say the following blessing: "Blessed art thou, Lord, Our God, King of the universe, who made us holy

²³ KJV Translation: "If fire break out, and catch in thorns, so that the stacks of corn, or the standing corn, or the field, be consumed therewith; he that kindled the fire (from *Bi'er*) shall surely make restitution." JPS Translation: "If fire break out, and catch in thorns, so that the shocks of corn, or the standing corn, or the field are consumed; he that kindled the fire (from *Bi'er*) shall surely make restitution."

²⁴ In this verse, the *Hiph'il* verbal form is used. This form also has the causative sense.

with His commandments and commanded us to light Shabbat Candles.” It should be noted that nowhere in the written Torah, or even in the Rabbinic Oral Torah, is it commanded to light Shabbat candles. Some Rabbinic and Academic sources even claim that the purpose of lighting Shabbat Candles and saying their blessing is to spite the Karaites on this issue. There can be no doubt that this is an addition to the law and as such is in violation of Deuteronomy 4:2. This is not acceptable to those who wish to follow the commandments set down in the Torah.²⁵

²⁵ The understanding that the “Blessing over the Shabbat Candles” is in violation of the Torah holds even if one disagrees with the analysis about why Karaites do not permit any fires on Shabbat. The practice is what the book of Isaiah refers to as “laws of men learned by custom” (Isaiah 29:13).